Mobile Money and the Gender Gap in Financial Inclusion

Evidence from the Global Findex 2025

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Overview

- **Question:** Does mobile money access help close the gender gap in financial inclusion?
- **Data:** World Bank Global Findex 2025 — 152 countries, 2024
- **Approach:** Descriptive analysis, covariation, and regression
- **Finding:** Mobile money is negatively associated with the gender gap, but the effect is modest and not statistically significant — suggesting broader structural barriers remain

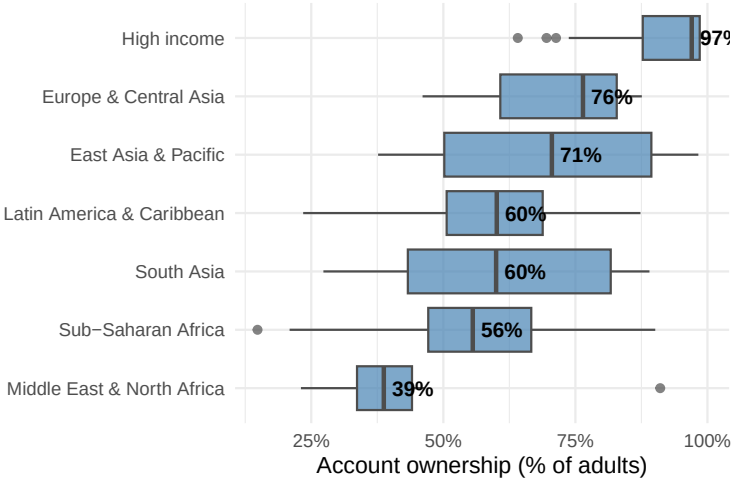
Data

- **Source:** World Bank Global Findex 2025
- **Coverage:** 152 countries, 2024
- **Unit of analysis:** Country-level averages by gender
- **Key variables:**
  - *Account ownership:* share of adults with a financial account
  - *Mobile money:* share of adults with a mobile money account
  - *Gender gap:* men's minus women's account ownership rate (positive = men higher)

Statistic	Value
Mean ownership, men	73.6%
Mean ownership, women	67.6%
Mean gender gap	6.1%
Max gender gap	33.8%
Min gender gap	-14.1%

Financial Inclusion Around the World

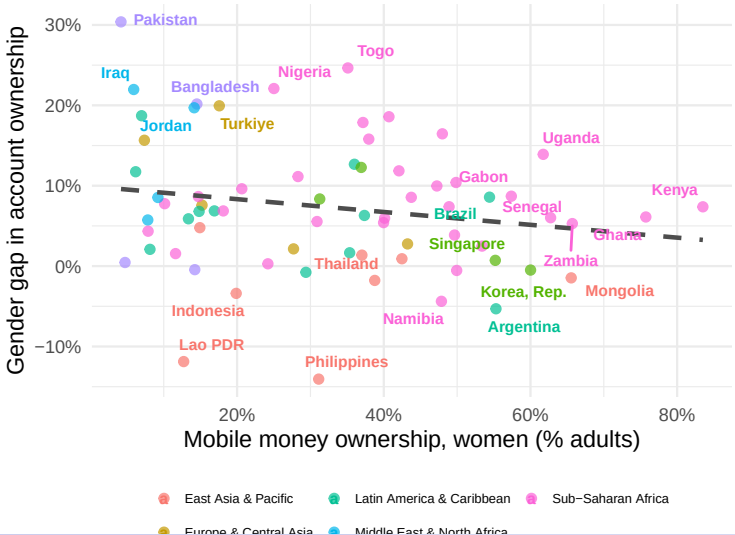
- Account ownership varies dramatically across regions
- Middle East & North Africa shows the lowest median
- High-income countries cluster near full inclusion



Source: World Bank Global Findex 2025

Mobile Money and the Gender Gap

- Countries with higher mobile money adoption show a smaller gender gap
- The negative trend is largely driven by Sub-Saharan Africa's high mobile money adoption
- Considerable variation around the trend suggests other factors are at play



Regression Analysis

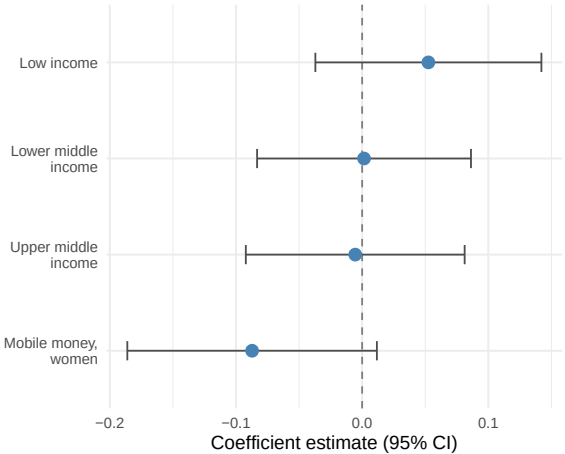


Figure 3

- Mobile money shows a negative but marginally significant association ($p = 0.089$)
- Income group adds little explanatory power
- Structural barriers beyond income and mobile access likely drive the gap

Conclusion

Mobile money alone won't close the gender gap.

- Account ownership gaps persist across most regions, even where mobile money is widespread
- Mobile money shows a negative but marginally significant association with the gender gap ($p = 0.089$)
- Structural barriers beyond income and mobile access — legal rights, education, social norms — likely drive the gap

Future work: longitudinal analysis tracking how mobile money expansion affects within-country gender gaps over time